

3.2 From Low-Tech To Hi-Tech

At the start of the '90s, the gaming industry was at crossroads. CDs had gained popularity for their superior quality and storage capabilities. This meant console manufacturers had to make a choice—whether to continue using cartridges or moving to CDs. While some companies stuck to the cartridge system right until it died a painful death, others were pioneers in making the switch to CD.

The first console to feature CDs was the NEC TurboGrafx-16, a.k.a. the NEC PC Engine. Although it was launched as a cartridge-based console in 1989, in Japan, NEC also shipped an add-on CD-ROM drive. This was also later released in the USA later under the name Turbo CD. It wasn't successful, because the CD-ROM attachment was extremely expensive, and games featured on the CDs were very graphics-oriented. The gameplay was left in the lurch, and novelty of the CD soon wore thin.

This meant that cartridge games would be around for a few years yet. The Sega Genesis was the next console to be released, and was basically a cartridge console (though it came with a CD add-on). Sega had learnt from the relative failure of the SMS. This time round they got as many third-party game developers to sign up as they possibly could. But their trump card was a game by the name of *Sonic the Hedgehog*. This game alone helped sell nearly six million units of the Genesis between 1990-91. In other words, Sega had struck gold with the Genesis.

With the Genesis rapidly taking control of the market, Nintendo had to do something quickly. They followed up the NES with the release of the Super NES, or SNES, in 1991. It was one of the last major consoles to use a cartridge system. Due to the stiff competition, Nintendo was forced to drop the strict licensing policies they had followed until then. Nintendo decided to allow any company to produce Nintendo games, but still rated the games themselves and promoted the better ones.